tomatoes

The tomato juice had started to prune my fingers. I hooked a seed from under my nail and flicked it away. It hit the grey glass in front of me and dropped out of sight. as Rain pressed against the window in small repeated taps. I put my thumb on the top of the tomato and pushed down until it gave in slightly. The flesh was soft and pasty, not firm. I slid my finger under the cross-cut I'd made earlier and lifted the skin. It came away in a thin, translucent strip, curling as it peeled off.

I set the peeled tomato aside and picked up the next one. My eyes still set on the window in front of me, the glass looked tired up close: dust caught in the corners, a burn mark shaped like an oval, shallow scratches from utensils dragged across it. The smell of tomato juice condensing around me. I wiped my fingers on the towel and kept going. I still had twenty-five left. I was rushing before my sister returned. He would be here soon. my sister said the sauce had to be perfect for him, that he notices things like that.

Each tomato required the same small cut, the same pressure, the same peeling. The skins came off in damp ribbons and stuck to my fingers before dropping onto the counter.

“You bruise them when you do that.” she said, appearing behind me. “I'm not bruising them.”

“You always press too hard", "He'll notice if they're bruised."

She had already set the table. One extra plate. A glass she'd wiped twice with the corner of her cardigan.

The knife wasn't sharp enough to feel clean. It dragged slightly when I scored the tops, and I had to go over the cross twice sometimes. I tried to make the cuts neat anyway. I didn't want any of them to split too far down. I didn't want them to fall apart. The marble under my hands stayed the same: dust, scratches, the brown oval mark that looked like someone had set down a hot pan and never mentioned it again. Outside, the rain kept tapping the window. She was leaning in the doorway now, arms folded, watching me the way she watches everything I do.

I looked down at the soggy tomatoes. They were sinking into each other, their smooth surfaces wrinkling where they touched. They looked tired. opoopj

“You think I can't tell?” she said quietly. Walking over.

“Tell what?”

“When you rush.”

“I'm not rushing.”

“You are.” She set the tomato down carefully, like it was fragile. “You always want to finish first. Even if it means ruining it.”

“You always think you know better.”

“I do know better,” she said. Cruelly.

I stared at her hands. They were too clean. Dry. Untouched. Her nails long, painted lime green.

Mine were stained red to the wrist, skin folding into itself.

“You don’t even like cooking,” she continued.

My teeth grinded and my thumb dug into the next tomato without me meaning to. The skin split down the side. Juice ran over my knuckles and into the thin lines of my palm. It felt warmer than it should have. I wiped my hand on the towel again. The towel was damp now, heavy.

She returned to the same place against the wall.

The rain sounded different. Not louder, just closer, as if it had moved from the window to somewhere inside the room. I glanced up, but the glass was the same dull grey, streaked and tired. The reflection looking back at me felt slightly delayed, like it was thinking before copying me. The smell had thickened. Still tomato, but underneath it something else, something faintly sweet and faintly wrong. I told myself it was just the pile sitting there too long.

The rain stopped. Not gradually. Just stopped. The silence that was pressed and full. I could hear the small sounds inside the room now: the faint hum of the fridge, the soft stick of tomato against marble countertop, my own breathing. My own heartbeat.

“You never leave me the firm ones,” I said. “You choose first. You always choose first.”

I dropped the knife.

It hit the marble with a sharp crack and skidded, stopping near the brown burn mark. The sound seemed to echo longer than it should have. I didn’t move to pick it up, something shifted in the kitcen.Not loud. Not clear. Just a small, wet sound, slurping. I looked at the pile of tomatoes.

“You’re overthinking it,” my sister said.

I relaxed my muscles, lowering my shoulders.

But as I swiveled around I was met with the chalky white wall.

My eyes darted to the corners of the room, and landed on the black rot that was sprouting on near the top. Crawling through the cement, and swimming in the milky paint that covered the wall. The rot resembled hair, stringy and messy.

“I’m right here,” she said again. Closer this time. Amused.

My throat tightened. “Where?”

A soft laugh. Wet. Muffled.

I twisted my hand behind me grabbing for the knife and scuttled to the other side of the kitchen towards the door. I tried tugging on it. The handle felt rubbery under my palm. I stuck my knife inside, hard, using all the strength I had, knuckles tensing, bicep twisting. But the tip of my knife was met with a pudgy wall.

The surface was dented and warm and I dragged the blade down. Grunting loudly

Red seeds and juice came spilling out, pouring, thick and endless, filling the room with that same sweet, rotting heat. The walls pulsed faintly, like a heartbeat.

“You always pressed too hard,” sister’s voice said, calm now. Patient.

The floor beneath me shifted, giving in slightly. I looked down. The marbled tiles had softened into glossy red flesh. The grout lines split open like seams.

“This is your fault,” I whispered.

A shape moved beneath the skin of the wall. A shadow pressing outward from inside, stretching the surface thin. I could see the outline now. Shoulders. A jaw. Fingers splayed against the membrane.

“Is it?” she asked.

The skin tore where her hand pushed through. Not violently. Slowly. The red stretched, translucent, before giving way. Her fingers emerged first, coated, glistening. Then her face, pressing through like something being born.

“You wanted to be inside it,” she said softly. “You always do.”

The kitchen shrank inward. The ceiling sagged. The counter curved around me.

I looked at my hands. They were no longer wrinkled from juice. They were smooth. Tight. Glossy.

My skin was reddening.

I could feel something pressing behind my ribs and swelling.

I tried to breathe but the air was thick, syrupy. Seeds on my tongue.

The walls pulsed again. And then I understood. I wasn’t in the kitchen. I was inside something round and ripening.

And somewhere outside, someone was scoring a careful cross into my skin.